

■ By Farzand Ahmed

It may sound bizarre but last week Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati reinstated 25 ips officers—suspended only recently—after they admitted in writing that they had, “committed irregularities in the recruitment of constables under political pressure” and “apologised” for their mistakes. Later, the Government clarified that “only suspension has been withdrawn but departmental as well as legal proceedings would continue.” Just two weeks back she had suspended Moradabad Divisional Commissioner Shyam Manohar Srivastava and eight other officials on charges of “laxity”. This was preceded by the suspension of Noida’s Chief Executive Officer Balwinder Kumar on charges of irregularities in his earlier stint as the MD of Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Corporation.

Mayawati had hit the suspension button immediately after taking oath in May when she drove to Ambedkar Park in Gomti Nagar and suspended two IAS officers—Satish Agrawal, the then principal secretary PWD and home, and B.B. Singh, vice-chairman, Lucknow Development Authority (LDA)—for poor maintenance of the park. A few weeks later she suspended Gorakhpur district magistrate Rakesh Kumar Goel for making an announcement that those opting for sterilisation would get preference in the allotment of arms licences. With suspensions becoming an order of the day, she surpassed her previous record of 2002-03 when she had suspended 12 IAS and three IPS officers in 15 months. Now, in a mere six months in office, she has suspended 5 IAS and 25 IPS officers while her predecessor Mulayam Singh had suspended 10 IAS officers during his three-and-a-half year rule.

Interestingly, the Personnel Department says, “four IAS officers are under suspension”, which means that officers are suspended publicly and reinstated silently, allegedly, so as to humiliate them in public. Senior officials say the situation is rather piquant as ministers have started suspending officers on flimsy grounds even without conducting an inquiry. Samajwadi Party leader Rakesh Singh Rana says suspension without explanation serves

BULLYING BAB



MULAYAM Vs MAYA

MULAYAM: AUGUST 2003-MAY 2007

SEPT 2003 Four IAS officers suspended in connection with Taj Corridor scam

OCT 2003 One IAS, two IPS officers suspended following public complaints

JAN 2004 Two IAS, one IPS suspended over laxity in issuing arm-licences

JUNE 2004 Two IAS officers suspended over illegal mining on forest land

MAYAWATI: MAY-DEC 2007

MAY 2007 Two IAS officers suspended over “poor maintenance of park”

JUNE 2007 IAS officer suspended over sterilisation, arms-licence comments

SEPT-OCT '07 25 IPS officers suspended over irregularities in recruitment

NOV 2007 IAS officer suspended over refusal to allot plot to a politician. Four police officers suspended for lack of follow-up on FIRs, seven others suspended later and disciplinary action ordered against 23 officers.

DEC 2007 Disciplinary action ordered against 95 “careless” officers

PLIANT PEN PUSHERS: Officials at a meeting (top) Mayawati (right)

twin purposes, “Mayawati wants to terrorise the bureaucracy and bring officers to their knees so that they not only carry out her orders, whether legal or illegal, but also use them for harassing opponents.” But simultaneously, the bureaucracy is being demoralised and administration is collapsing.

The suspensions have led to restlessness in the secretariat and police headquarters and the Department of Appointments & Personnel has issued a fiat reminding ministers that they should desist from announcing suspensions publicly and adhere to norms. The chief minister has now changed track and adopted “punitive” action that includes summary transfer and warnings as well as entry of “adverse” remarks in the confidential character rolls (CCR) in the service records of officials. This is perceived to be equally dangerous as it affects promotions. On November 26, on a round of Varanasi, Gorakhpur, Basti, Azamgarh and Vindhyachal divisions, Mayawati ordered punitive action against 33 offi-